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NAME OF COURSE: TARTEEL & TADABBUR
FACILITATOR: MUALLIMA SHAKIRAH HUNTER
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REFRAMING MY NIYYAT FOR STUDYING THE QURAAN



Umm Abbad Academy
Tafseer and Tadabbur Course Booklet
Facilitator:Mu'allima Shakirah Hunter

Course Overview

This course is designed to provide students with a deep understanding of the Quran through Tafseer (exegesis) and Tadabbur. The course will explore key verses, their meanings, and the spiritual guidance they offer, while also emphasising the deep connection to the mesages within the Quranic recitation.

Course Objectives

1. To develop a deeper understanding of the Quranic message.
2. To learn the correct application of Tadabbur during recitation.
3. To strengthen spiritual connection through Tafseer and reflection on Quranic verses.
4. To inspire students to implement Quranic guidance in their daily lives.

Introduction :

Al-Anbiya 21:10
لَقَدْ أَنزَلْنَآ إِلَيْكُمْ كِتَٰبًا فِيهِ ذِكْرُكُمْ ۖ أَفَلَا تَعْقِلُونَ

We have certainly sent down to you a Book in which is your mention (your honor and distinction)"
[Al Ambiya-10]

Al-Saadi wrote commenting on this verse:
This verse is confirmed by what actually occurred. The believers in the Messenger, those who took heed by the Quran, from the Companions and those who came afterwards, achieved prominence, distinction, great renown and honor among the kings. Such is something well-known to everyone. Similarly, it is well known what happened to those who did not raise their heads with the Quran and were not guided or purified through it. [They suffered from] disgrace, disdain, ignobility, and unhappiness. There is no way to achieve the happiness of this world nor that of the Hereafter except by following the remembrance of this Book.
[As Saadi]

This principle applies to all times. If the believers want to be respected, to have honor and dignity and not live in disgrace and humiliation, Allah has shown them what they need to turn to: the Quran. If they turn to it and apply it in their lives, it will be the source of their honor and dignity in not just this temporary life but in the everlasting life in the Hereafter. Umar ibn al-Khattaab is quoted to have said about Islam itself, which directly implies the Quran also, "We were the most despised people and Allah honoured us and gave us strength through Islam. And if we ever seek such honor through something other than that which Allah honoured us by, Allah will then disgrace us."
In fact, the Prophet (peace be upon him) himself said about the Quran, "Verily, Allah exalts some people by this Book and He debases others by it. [Muslim]

The connection to true joy



NUR - LIGHT

Section One: Our relationship with the Qur'an- through the description of Allah Ta'ala Himself.

Al-Baqarah 2:2
ذَٰلِكَ ٱلْكِتَٰبُ لَا رَيْبَ ۛ فِيهِ ۛ هُدًى لِّلْمُتَّقِينَ

This is the Book about which there is no doubt, a guidance for those conscious of Allah -

1. The first aspect that one notes is that Allah refers to the Book with the demonstrative pronoun dhaalika, which would normally be translated as, "that" instead of "this." However, the word "that" is used for "this" for particular reasons. Siddiqi noted,

The demonstrative pronoun ["that"] indicates remoteness of distance, but at times it indicates esteem, honour and grandeur of that for which it is used as we find in the case of the Quran.

2. Second, the phrase is actually more comparable to something like, "This is the Book." It implies that it is the most complete book and that no other book deserves to be called a "book" like this book does. It is the real book that encompasses what no other previous book encompasses. In other words, Allah is pointing to the completeness.

3. Third, Allah mentions that this is a book concerning which there can be no doubt. It is the case that many disbelievers and skeptics doubt this book. However, that is not the meaning of this passage. The meaning is that the **proofs and evidence that this is a true and perfect revelation from Allah are so great and clear that there is in reality no room or reason for anyone to doubt this book.** This applies to the book as a whole and every portion of its guidance. There should be no doubt concerning anything that Allah has stated in this book. The absence of doubt, as al-Saadi points out, implies that the believer must be completely certain and satisfied that everything stated in this book is true.

4. Fourth, Allah describes this book as **"guidance."**
Commenting on this portion of the verse, al-Saadi noted,
Allah stated the word "guidance" without stating
its regimen or governing word. He did not say, "Guidance for the benefit of so and so," or "for the benefit of such and such purpose." [Such was not said] so that the concept of guidance may be left in its generality. It is guidance for all of the needs and benefits of the life of this world and that of the Hereafter. It is the guide for humans concerning fundamental and secondary aspects. It distinguishes truth from falsehood and what is sound from what is weak. And it makes clear for them how to follow the path that is beneficial for them in both their worldly affairs and their other worldly matters.3
This verse makes it clear that the Quran is first and foremost a book of guidance.

"A guidance for mankind and clear proofs for the guidance and the criterion [between right and wrong]" (al-Baqarah 185).
What these two verses, al-Baqarah 2 and al-Baqarah 185, imply is that the guidance of the Quran is there for everyone to see and benefit from. ***However, not everyone is gong to benefit from its wonderful guidance.*** *Only those who approach the Quran in the proper way, seeking to obey it and implement its guidance, will be the ones who truly benefit from the guidance of the Quran.*

Section One: Our relationship with the Qur'an- through the description of Allah Ta'ala Himself.

5. Allah also refers to Quran as rooh ("spirit"). Allah says,
Ash-Shura 42:52
وَكَذَٰلِكَ أَوْحَيْنَآ إِلَيْكَ رُوحًا مِّنْ أَمْرِنَا ۚ مَا كُنتَ تَدْرِى مَا ٱلْكِتَٰبُ وَلَا ٱلْإِيمَٰنُ وَلَٰكِن جَعَلْنَٰهُ نُورًا نَّهْدِى بِهِۦ مَن نَّشَآءُ مِنْ عِبَادِنَا ۚ وَإِنَّكَ لَتَهْدِىٓ إِلَىٰ صِرَٰطٍ مُّسْتَقِيمٍ

And thus We have revealed to you an inspiration of Our command. You did not know what is the Book or [what is] faith, but We have made it a light by which We guide whom We will of Our servants. And indeed, [O Muhammad], you guide to a straight path -

While commenting upon this verse, Saalih al-Fauzaan noted that *rooh implies the thing that gives life to a heart. In the same way that the physical heart's life is directly tied to a rooh, the spiritual life is also directly tied to a rooh, and that rooh is the Quran. It is this Quran that gives life to the spiritual heart. If the heart is void of the Quran, then it is in fact spiritually dead, no matter how much it may be physically alive in this world.*
The heart attains real life when it is joined with the Quran. It is by the teachings of the Quran that the heart truly knows its Lord and knows how to worship Him.

The heart then becomes filled with **love of Allah, fear of Allah**, **reverence for Him** and **hope in Him.** These are some of the key ingredients that are needed for a healthy heart. The heart is moved by the Quran in the same way that the physical heart is moved by the physical soul. The physical death that is the result of the loss of the rooh cannot compare to the spiritual death that is the result of being void of the spiritual rooh or the Quran. Physical death comes to believers, disbelievers, evildoers and even animals. Its result is a departure from this worldly life. A spiritual death is what the disbelievers are experiencing and its result is the painful abode of the Hell-fire forever.
Al-Raawi notes that people are very much aware of the result of the physical rooh leaving the body. When that happens, they take the body and bury it as it is not able to perform any action since its rooh has left. In a sense, it has become useless. At the same time, people disregard what happens when the effects of the Quran are no longer seen on a person. They do not see what happens to the person in both this life and the Hereafter when he has lost the rooh of the Quran. Without this rooh, a person is truly spiritually dead even though it looks to all around him that he is physically alive. He is dead because he is not even realizing his purpose in this life. He is living his life without heading toward its proper goal, hence, he may as well be physically dead.

6. In the same verse quoted above, as in other verses, Allah describes the Quran as a "light" (noor). Allah says,

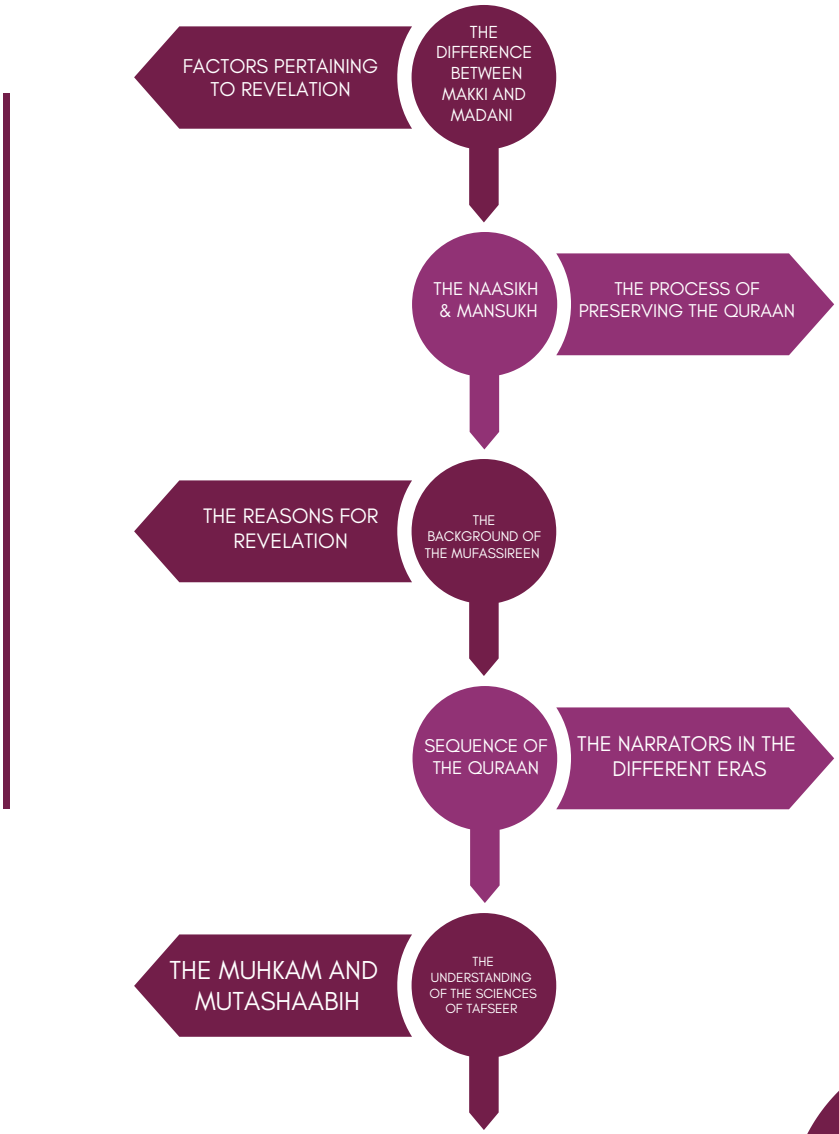
"Thus We have revealed to
you a rooh of Our command. You knew not what is the Book nor what is faith. But We have made it [this Quran] a light (noor) wherewith We guide whosoever of Our servants We will. And verily you guide [mankind] to the straight path" (al-Shoora 52).

Light is the thing that shows the person the path in front of him. It is by light that he can avoid the harmful objects in his way and follow the way that is most beneficial. However, this is different from the light that one physically senses in this world. This is a spiritual light. By this light, *one recognizes and understands what will benefit him in both his mundane and religious spheres*. He will recognize truth from falsehood and he will be following the path that leads to Paradise. 1
This light leads to the Straight Path and Allah's grace and mercy. However, as will be a recurring theme throughout this work, that light is only beneficial for one who follows it. Allah says,
"O mankind! Verily, there has come to you a convincing proof from your Lord, and We sent down to you a manifest light [thisQuran].

From the above it is clear that the Quran is the key to the believers' real and true life. Without the Quran, a person is suffering from a spiritual death and living in darkness. In fact, Allah has said in reference to the guidance that He revealed and blesses His followers with.

SECTION TWO: WHAT IS ULUMUL QUR'AN?

WHAT IS MEANT BY ULUMUL QUR'AN?



SECTION TWO: DEFINITION AND NAMES OF THE HOLY QUR'AN.

The Holy Qur'an is defined as the Kalam of Allah Ta'ala - a miraculous word of Allah Subhaanahu wata'ala revealed upon the seal of all Prophets Muhammed (s) through Jibril Al Amin (as)



Section Two: What is Asbabun Nuzool?

The Sababun Nuzool is the reason for revelation. There are many Ayaat of the Quraan Al Kareem that cannot be understood except with a deep background of the incidents surrounding the revelation itself. For example in the ayah of qiblah:

Al-Baqarah 2:115

وَلِلَّهِ ٱلْمَشْرِقُ وَٱلْمَغْرِبُ فَأَيْنَمَا تُوَلُّوا۟ فَثَمَّ وَجْهُ ٱللَّهِ ۚ إِنَّ ٱللَّهَ وَٰسِعٌ عَلِيمٌ

And to Allah belongs the east and the west. So wherever you [might] turn, there is the Face of Allah . Indeed, Allah is all-Encompassing and Knowing.

If this ayah is not understood within the larger context then a person might gain the incoreect understanding that one may perform salaah in whatever direction one wishes. Na'uzubillah.

Therefore we understand that learning the story behind the ayah or the incident itself is of paramount importance.

A great Mufassir Waahidi says: "It is impossible to understand the Tafseer of the Qur'an , without stopping to reflect on its stories and to explain its reason for revelation. Ibn Taymiya (ra) has said : "recognition of the reason of revelation assists in understanding the meaning of the aayah.

Benefits of knowing the sababun nuzool:

1. Recognition of the root of the laws of Islam
2. To be able to specify a law with the reason for the law
3. To be able to recognise the name of whoever is being spoken about in the Ayah itself.

Section Two: Who were the mufassireen?

Allah revealed His magnificent Book to serve as a constitution for Muslims and as a methodology for them to follow in their lives. They take light from its illumination, guidance from its teachings, and wisdom from its noble instructions and wise systems, which elevate them to the peak of happiness and honor. It raises them to the heights of glory and dignity, qualifies them to lead humanity, and makes them the masters and leaders in this life. They guide nations to a life of honor and dignity and lead them to the shores of safety, stability, and peace.

There is no doubt that humanity today is stumbling in the darkness of misery and ignorance and drowning in the currents of moral decay and the worship of idols. It has no savior except Islam through the guidance of the Qur'an and its wise systems, which encompass all elements of happiness for humankind, based on the wisdom of the Creator. Clearly, acting upon these teachings is not possible without understanding and reflecting upon the Qur'an and uncovering the guidance and instruction it contains. This can only be achieved through elucidation and clarification, as the verses of the Qur'an themselves indicate, which is what we call (the science of Tafsir). This is particularly crucial in these recent times when the linguistic proficiency of Arabic has declined, even among the descendants of Arabs themselves. Tafsir is the key to unlocking the treasures and jewels contained in this majestic Book. Without it, it is impossible to access these treasures, pearls, and gems, no matter how much people repeat the words of the Qur'an or recite its verses.

It is unfortunate that Muslims are content with only the words of the Qur'an, reciting and singing its melodies at mosques, graves, and official celebrations, without benefiting from its teachings or adhering to its guidance. The Qur'an's portion of their lives is reduced to the delight of hearing it or seeking blessings through its recitation. This is what the Prophet (peace be upon him) meant when he said, They take the Qur'an as songs. Muslims have forgotten—or ignored—that the greatest blessing of the Qur'an lies in reflecting on it, understanding it, and adhering to its guidance, benefiting from its teachings, and aligning their lives with its commandments and prohibitions.

Allah says: [This is] a blessed Book which We have revealed to you, [O Muhammad], that they might reflect upon its verses and that those of understanding would be reminded.* (Qur'an 38:29)

And He says: Do they not then reflect upon the Qur'an, or are there locks upon their hearts?" (Qur'an 47:24)

He also says: "And We have certainly made the Qur'an easy for remembrance, so is there any who will remember?" (Qur'an 54:17)

Muslims today resemble a thirsty man dying of thirst while water is within his reach or an animal starving while carrying provisions on its back. How fitting are the words of the poet:

"Like camels in a desert dying of thirst, while water is on their backs in buckets."]

Indeed, the Prophet (peace be upon him) was truthful when he said, "I have left among you two things; you will never go astray as long as you hold on to them: the Book of Allah and my Sunnah."

WHY DO WE INTERPRET THE QUR'AN?

This is a question that crosses every person's mind: *Why do we interpret the Qur'an?* Is it merely to perfect its recitation? Or to remove the veil from its obscure meanings? Or to uncover its secrets and highlight its virtues? No... it is not for any of these reasons alone. Instead, it is to free people from the worship of creation to the worship of the Creator alone, to connect hearts with the Sustainer of the universe, the Lord of the Throne, the Most Magnificent.

The Noble Qur'an is the constitution of the nation, the guidance of the Creator, and Allah's law for the people of the earth. It is the divine light, the heavenly guidance, and the eternal comprehensive legislation that addresses every need of humanity in matters of religion and worldly affairs. No wonder it is the source of happiness for those who follow its guidance and adhere to its teachings. It is a cure for the illnesses of the heart and a remedy for the evils that plague society. Allah says: *"And We send down of the Qur'an that which is healing and mercy for the believers, but it does not increase the wrongdoers except in loss."* (Qur'an 17:82)

THE MEANING OF TA'WIL (INTERPRETATION):

Linguistically, Ta'wil derives from the root "أَوَّل" (to return), implying that the interpreter returns the verse to what it potentially signifies in meaning. Some scholars equate Ta'wil with Tafsir (exegesis). For instance, the author of Al-Qamus states: "He interpreted the speech (ta'wilahu) and explained it (fassarahu)."This is also reflected in the verse: "[But those firm in knowledge say], 'We believe in it; all [of it] is from our Lord. But no one knows its [true] interpretation except Allah.'" (Qur'an 3:7)

In Islamic terminology, early scholars used Ta'wil synonymously with Tafsir. For example, Ibn Jarir Al-Tabari in his Tafsir often stated, "The statement regarding the interpretation (ta'wil) of this verse is..." and then elaborated on the meaning. Similarly, Mujahid mentioned that "The scholars engage in Ta'wil," referring to their explanation of the Qur'an.

However, a group of later scholars distinguished between Tafsir and Ta'wil.

1. Tafsir: Refers to the apparent, explicit meaning of the Qur'anic verse, which is clear and directly understood.

2. Ta'wil: Involves preferring one of the possible meanings of a verse that accommodates multiple interpretations.

The Scholar Al-Suyut elaborated on this in his book Al-Itqan fi Ulum Al-Qur'an, citing numerous opinions of the scholars. The most accurate view, close to correctness, is that Tafsiris the unveiling of the apparent meanings of the Qur'an, while Ta'wil pertains to the hidden meanings and divine secrets inferred by the knowledgeable.

Al-Alusi also supported this distinction, stating, "Among authors, it is widely accepted without objection that Ta'wil refers to sacred meanings and divine insights conveyed to the hearts of those who are spiritually aware, whereas Tafsir pertains to the evident and apparent meanings."*

Summary:

- -Tafsir: Represents the clear and apparent meanings of Qur'anic verses, explicitly denoting the intended message of Allah.
- - Ta'wil:Refers to deeper, inferred meanings extracted from Qur'anic verses, requiring contemplation and reasoning. It encompasses multiple possible interpretations, with scholars favoring the most likely meaning based on evidence. However, this preference is not definitive, as only Allah knows the true, ultimate meaning of His words: *"And no one knows its [true] interpretation except Allah..."* (Qur'an 3:7).

Section Two: The Categories of Tafseer

"TAFSIR" AND ITS CATEGORIES

The divine meanings of the Qur'an flow from the unseen realms to the hearts of the spiritually aware, distinct from the apparent meanings of Tafsir.
Tafsir is divided into three main categories according to precise scholarly terminology:

1. TAFSIR BY NARRATION (TAFSIR BIL-RIWAYA):
This is also known as "Tafsir by Transmission" or "Tafsir bil-Ma'thur."

2. TAFSIR BY REASONING (TAFSIR BIL-RA'Y):
This is also referred to as "Interpretation by Opinion."

3. TAFSIR BY INDICATION (TAFSIR BIL-ISHARA):
Scholars refer to this as "Allusive Tafsir."

Each of these categories will be discussed in detail, Insha'Allah.

1. TAFSIR BY NARRATION (TAFSIR BIL-MA'THUR)

This includes interpretations derived from the Qur'an itself, the Sunnah, or the statements of the Companions. It explains Allah's intended meaning using:

-The Qur'an to explain the Qur'an:
For instance, the verse:
"Permitted to you are the grazing livestock..." (Qur'an 5:1)
is explained by another verse:
"Prohibited to you are dead animals, blood, the flesh of swine, and that which has been dedicated to other than Allah..." (Qur'an 5:3).

- The Qur'an through the Sunnah:
An example is the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) interpreting "oppression" (*zulm*) in the verse:
"They who believe and do not mix their belief with injustice..."(Qur'an 6:82)
as "shirk" (associating partners with Allah), supported by the verse:
"Indeed, shirk is a great oppression." (Qur'an 31:13).

- The Qur'an through the sayings of the Companions:
Their explanations are considered valid because they witnessed the revelation, understood its contexts, and learned directly from the Prophet (peace be upon him).

This category of Tafsir is considered the highest and most reliable form because:

1. Qur'an explaining the Qur'an: Allah is the best to clarify His own words.
2. Sunnah explaining the Qur'an:The Prophet's mission included explaining the Qur'an. Allah says:
"And We revealed to you the message that you may make clear to the people what was sent down to them." (Qur'an 16:44).

Examples include:

- The verse:
"We revealed it on a blessed night..."(Qur'an 44:3)
is explained in another verse as the "Night of Decree" (Laylat al-Qadr):
"Indeed, We sent it down during the Night of Decree."(Qur'an 97:1).

- The Prophet explaining the "middle prayer" in the verse:
"Maintain with care the [obligatory] prayers and [in particular] the middle prayer..." (Qur'an 2:238)
as the Asr prayer.

The interpretation of "those who have evoked [Your] anger" and "those who are astray":
In Surah Al-Fatihah:
"The path of those You have bestowed favor upon, not of those who have evoked [Your] anger or of those who are astray"(Qur'an 1:7).
The Prophet (peace be upon him) explained:
"Those who have evoked [Your] anger are the Jews, and those who are astray are the Christians."

The interpretation of "increase" as seeing Allah's face:
In the verse:
"For those who have done good is the best reward and even more..." (Qur'an 10:26).
The Prophet (peace be upon him) explained that "even more" refers to the believers seeing Allah's face on the Day of Judgment.

. The interpretation of "strength" as archery:
In the verse:
"And prepare against them whatever you are able of strength..." (Qur'an 8:60).
The Prophet (peace be upon him) said:
"Indeed, strength is archery. Indeed, strength is archery."

The interpretation of "that Day it will report its news":
In the verse:
That Day it will report its news"Qur'an 99:4).
The Prophet (peace be upon him) asked:
"Do you know what its news is?"
They replied: *"Allah and His Messenger know best."
He said:
"Its news is that it will testify against every servant, male and female, about what they did on its surface. It will say: 'You did this and that on such and such day.'"

THE EXCELLENCE OF THESE TWO METHODS OF INTERPRETATION:

There is no doubt that interpreting the Qur'an with the Qur'an and interpreting it with the Sunnah are the highest and most reliable forms of tafsir. They are accepted without question because:

1. Interpreting the Qur'an with the Qur'an: Allah is the most knowledgeable about His own words. The Qur'an is free from falsehood, as Allah says:
*"Falsehood cannot approach it from before it or from behind it." (Qur'an 41:42).

2. Interpreting the Qur'an with the Sunnah:The Prophet (peace be upon him) was sent to explain the Qur'an. Allah says:
"And We revealed to you the message that you may make clear to the people what was sent down to them." (Qur'an 16:44).
Any explanation or clarification from the Prophet (peace be upon him) that is transmitted through an authentic chain of narration is undoubtedly reliable.

Thus, Tafsir bil-Ma'thur is among the most esteemed forms of Qur'anic interpretation, provided its narrations are authentic.

INTERPRETATION OF THE COMPANIONS:

The third category of Tafsir bil-Ma'thur (interpretation by narration) is the interpretation of the Companions. This category is also considered reliable and accepted because the Companions (may Allah be pleased with them) were in direct contact with the Prophet (peace be upon him). They drew directly from the pure source of his knowledge, witnessed the revelation and its context, and were aware of the reasons behind the revelation of various verses. Their pure hearts, sound natural disposition, and high eloquence and linguistic mastery uniquely qualified them for a correct and profound understanding of Allah's words. They were able to grasp the meanings and secrets of the Qur'an more deeply than any other group.

It has been said:
"The interpretation of a Companion who witnessed the revelation and its context has the ruling of a marfu' (elevated) hadith."
This means that the interpretation of a Companion is regarded as having the same status as a Prophetic tradition directly attributed to the Prophet (peace be upon him). Therefore, it falls under the category of ma'thur (narrated) tafsir.

INTERPRETATION OF THE TABI'UN (SUCCESSORS):

As for the Tabi'un—the generation that followed the Companions—there is a difference of opinion regarding their interpretations:

1. Some scholars classify their interpretations as ma'thur (narrated) because they predominantly learned from the Companions.
2. Others categorize their interpretations as Tafsir bil-Ra'y (interpretation by reasoning), meaning their interpretations are treated like those of other scholars who rely on linguistic principles and reasoning without being strictly bound to narrated traditions.

A NOTE ON *TAFSIR BIL-MA'THUR:

Tafsir bil-Ma'thur is one of the most esteemed and reliable forms of tafsir, provided the chain of narration is authentic, whether it is traced to the Prophet (peace be upon him) or to the Companions. It is essential to verify the authenticity of these narrations when relying on them.

Ibn Kathir (may Allah have mercy on him) stated:
"Much of the tafsir that has been narrated contains elements introduced by Jewish and Persian heretics, as well as Muslim converts from the People of the Book. Most of these narrations pertain to the stories of the Prophets and their communities, their scriptures, miracles, and the histories of others, such as the People of the Cave, and so on."

Therefore, it is crucial to verify the authenticity of these narrations before accepting them.

Section Two: The Most Renowned Qur'anic Exegetes Among the Companions:

THE MOST RENOWNED QUR'ANIC EXEGETES AMONG THE COMPANIONS:

Al-Suyuti mentioned in Al-Itqan:
"Among the Companions, ten are renowned for their tafsir: the four Rightly-Guided Caliphs(ra), Abdullah ibn Mas'ud (ra), Abdullah ibn Abbas(ra), Ubayy ibn Ka'b (ra), Zayd ibn Thabit (ra), Abu Musa Al-Ash'ari (ra), and Abdullah ibn Al-Zubayr (ra). Among the caliphs, the one most frequently narrated from is Ali ibn Abi Talib, may Allah honor his face, while the narrations from the other three are very limited, likely due to their early passing."*

THE LIMITED NARRATIONS FROM ABU BAKR, UMAR, AND UTHMAN:

As Al-Suyuti explained, the limited number of narrations from Abu Bakr, Umar, and Uthman can be attributed to the brevity of their caliphates and their early demise. Moreover, they lived during a time when most people were knowledgeable about the Qur'an, having been in close companionship with the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him). They were already familiar with the Qur'an's secrets and rulings.

As for Ali (may Allah be pleased with him), he lived longer after the other caliphs and during a time when Islam expanded rapidly. Many non-Arabs entered Islam, and a new generation of the Companions' children emerged who needed to study and understand the Qur'an. This circumstance led to more narrations being attributed to Ali compared to the other caliphs.

. Abdullah ibn Abbas (The Leading Qur'anic Exegete):

Abdullah ibn Abbas (may Allah be pleased with him) was a scholar of this nation and the cousin of the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him), who prayed for him, saying:
"O Allah, grant him understanding in religion and teach him the interpretation (ta'wil)."

He was known as "Tarjuman Al-Qur'an" (the Interpreter of the Qur'an). Abdullah ibn Mas'ud (ra) said:
"What a great interpreter of the Qur'an Abdullah ibn Abbas is!"*

He was the most knowledgeable of the Companions in interpreting the Qur'an. Even as a young man, he earned the admiration of senior Companions for his profound understanding. Umar (may Allah be pleased with him) often included him in his advisory council alongside the senior Companions of Badr, even though some objected due to his youth.

Al-Bukhari narrates through Sa'id ibn Jubayr from Ibn Abbas:
"Umar [ra] used to include me in the company of the elders of Badr. Some of them found it displeasing and said: 'Why do you include this young man when we have sons his age?' Umar [ra] replied: 'You know his status and knowledge.'

One day, Umar asked them about the verse:
'When the victory of Allah has come and the conquest...' (Qur'an 110:1).
Some replied: 'It refers to Allah's help and victory for us.' Others remained silent. Umar then turned to Ibn Abbas and asked: 'Do you say the same?' He replied: 'No.' Umar asked: 'What do you say?' Ibn Abbas responded: 'It signifies the approaching death of the Messenger of Allah (peace be upon him). When Allah grants His help and the conquest, it is a sign for you to glorify your Lord and seek His forgiveness, as the end is near.' Umar said: 'I do not know any interpretation of it except what you have said.'"*

This incident demonstrates Ibn Abbas's profound understanding and precise reasoning, qualities that only those deeply rooted in knowledge possess.

THE PROPHET'S PRAYER FOR IBN ABBAS:

The Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) once embraced Ibn Abbas and prayed:
"O Allah, grant him understanding of religion and teach him the interpretation (ta'wil)."
In another narration:
"O Allah, teach him wisdom."

He was also called *"Al-Bahr"* (The Ocean) due to his vast knowledge.

One man once asked Abdullah ibn Umar about the verse:
"The heavens and the earth were a joined entity, and We separated them" (Qur'an 21:30).
Ibn Umar [ra]responded:
"Go to Ibn Abbas and ask him, then come back and inform me."*
The man went to Ibn Abbas [ra], who explained:
"The heavens were a closed entity, preventing rain, and the earth was a closed entity, preventing vegetation. Then Allah caused the rain to fall and the earth to sprout."
When the man returned and informed Ibn Umar [ra], he remarked:
"I always admired Ibn Abbas' ability in interpreting the Qur'an."

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2. ABDULLAH IBN MAS'UD:

Abdullah ibn Mas'ud (may Allah be pleased with him) was another prominent Companion known for his knowledge of tafsir. He was one of the earliest Muslims and had the honor of being among the first to declare his faith publicly. He served the Prophet (peace be upon him) closely, carrying his sandals and accompanying him wherever he went. This close relationship made him one of the most learned Companions regarding the Qur'an.

A Narration from Al-Bukhari and Muslim:Abdullah ibn Mas'ud said:
"By Allah, there is no chapter of the Qur'an except that I know where it was revealed, and there is no verse of the Qur'an except that I know why it was revealed. If I knew of anyone more knowledgeable about the Qur'an than me, whom the camels could reach, I would travel to him."
This highlights the significant contributions of the Companions to Qur'anic interpretation, emphasizing their deep understanding and proximity to the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him).

THE EXEGETES AMONG THE SUCCESSORS (TABI'UN):

When discussing the Qur'anic commentators among the Tabi'un, they are considered a large and significant group, far outnumbering the Companions. This is because the number of Companions known for tafsir does not exceed ten, as noted by Al-Suyuti in Al-Itqan. The names of these Companions have already been mentioned, along with brief biographies of the most prominent among them.

However, the Tabi'un had a much larger number of exegetes. They gained widespread fame, and many among them became distinguished scholars, dedicating themselves to the study and interpretation of the Qur'an. The majority of interpretations we have today were transmitted from them. The Tabi'un can be classified into three major groups based on geographical regions:

1. The Scholars of Mecca
2. The Scholars of Medina
3. The Scholars of Iraq

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1. The Scholars of Mecca:

This group derived their knowledge from the "Sheikh of Exegetes," Tarjuman al-Qur'an (Interpreter of the Qur'an), Abdullah ibn Abbas (may Allah be pleased with him). Al-Suyuti quotes Ibn Taymiyyah, who said:
"The most knowledgeable people in tafsir are the people of Mecca, as they were the students of Abdullah ibn Abbas."

Many prominent scholars emerged from this group, including renowned figures such as:

Mujahid ibn Jabr
'Ata ibn Abi Raba
'Ikrimah (the freed slave of Ibn Abbas)
- Tawoos ibn Kaysan
- Saeed ibn Jubayr

We will briefly discuss the biographies of these notable scholars.

MUJAHID IBN JABR [RA]

Mujahid ibn Jabr, born in the year 21 AH and passed away in 104 AH, was a prominent scholar of Qur'anic interpretation. His full name is Mujahid ibn Jabr, and his title was Abu Al-Hajjaj Al-Makki. He is widely regarded as one of the foremost experts in tafsir (Qur'anic exegesis). Al-Dhahabi described him as:
"The Sheikh of reciters and exegetes, without dispute."

He studied under Abdullah ibn Abbas (may Allah be pleased with him), one of the most renowned interpreters of the Qur'an, and was among his closest and most distinguished students. Al-Bukhari and many other exegetes relied extensively on Mujahid's interpretations in their works. He traveled extensively and later settled in Kufa. It is said that whenever he heard of something extraordinary, he would seek it out to investigate and verify it.

HIS APPROACH TO TAFSIR:

Mujahid learned the interpretation of the Qur'an directly from Abdullah ibn Abbas [ra]. He studied it with deep understanding, reflecting carefully on each verse. Mujahid [ra] himself narrated:
"I presented the Qur'an to Ibn Abbas three times, stopping at every single verse to ask about its meaning: Why was it revealed, and how was it revealed?"

This methodical and detailed approach reflects Mujahid's dedication to understanding the Qur'an's profound meanings and secrets.

SCHOLARLY PRAISE FOR MUJAHID:

- Imam Al-Nawawi [ra] said:
"If a tafsir comes to you from Mujahid, it is sufficient for you," implying that Mujahid's [ra] interpretations were comprehensive and reliable, making them superior to those of others.

Mujahid's tafsir is widely recognized for its depth, precision, and close connection to the teachings of Abdullah ibn Abbas[ra] His interpretations are considered foundational and highly respected in the field of Qur'anic studies.

ATA IBN ABI RABAH

Born in 27 AH and passed away in 114 AH, `Ata ibn Abi Rabah was a prominent Tabi'i and one of the most esteemed scholars in Islamic jurisprudence and tafsir. He was widely regarded for his trustworthiness and reliability in narration.

Imam Abu Hanifa [ra] once said:
"I have never met anyone better than `Ata ibn Abi Rabah."

Qatadah [ra] remarked:
"The most knowledgeable of the Tabi'un are four: `Ata ibn Abi Rabah in the knowledge of rituals, Sa'id ibn Jubayr in tafsir, and so on."

He passed away in Mecca, where he was buried, at the age of 87.

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2. `IKRIMAH (THE FREED SLAVE OF IBN ABBAS)

Born in 25 AH and passed away in 115 AH, `Ikrimah was a distinguished scholar of tafsir and the freed slave of Abdullah ibn Abbas. Imam Al-Shafi'i said:
"There remains no one more knowledgeable about the Book of Allah than `Ikrimah."

He learned the Qur'an and Sunnah directly from Ibn Abbas and was known for his vast knowledge. `Ikrimah would often say:
"I have explained everything between the two covers (of the Qur'an), and everything I tell you about the Qur'an is from Ibn Abbas."

In Al-A'lam, his biography reads:
"Ikrimah ibn Abdullah Al-Barbari, Abu Abdullah, was a Tabi'i. He was among the most knowledgeable in tafsir and historical narratives. He traveled extensively, narrated from more than 300 individuals, including over 70 Tabi'un, and even ventured to Morocco to learn before returning to Medina."*

He passed away in Medina, on the same day as the renowned poet Katheer `Izzah. People said, "The most knowledgeable man and the best poet passed away on the same day."

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3. TAWOOS IBN KAYSAN

Born in 33 AH and passed away in 106 AH, Tawoos ibn Kaysan was an eminent scholar of tafsir, recognized for his brilliance, piety, and asceticism. He was a disciple of numerous Companions and learned from over 50 of them.

Tawoos was known for his devotion; he performed Hajj 40 times and was renowned for his humility and prayers being answered. Abdullah ibn Abbas said about him:
"I believe Tawoos will be among the people of Paradise."

In Al-A'lam, his biography states:
"Tawoos ibn Kaysan Al-Khawlani Al-Yamani, Abu Abdurrahman, was among the most prominent Tabi'un, known for his expertise in religion, hadith, and tafsir. He was ascetic, brave in advising rulers, and steadfast in his principles. He passed away in Muzdalifah while performing Hajj."*

Ibn Uyaynah said:
"There are three who avoided the rulers: Abu Dharr, Tawoos, and Al-Thawri."

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4. SA'ID IBN JUBAYR

Born in 45 AH and passed away in 94 AH, Sa'id ibn Jubayr was one of the most celebrated scholars of the Tabi'un. Known for his piety, profound knowledge of tafsir, and eloquence, he was a disciple of Abdullah ibn Abbas. Sufyan Al-Thawri said:
"Take tafsir from four: Sa'id ibn Jubayr, Mujahid, `Ikrimah, and Al-Dahhak."

Sa'id ibn Jubayr was known for his remarkable memory. Ibn Abbas praised him, saying:
"Be careful when narrating from me, for you have memorized much from me."

His Death:
Sa'id ibn Jubayr's life ended tragically at the hands of the tyrant Al-Hajjaj ibn Yusuf. When captured, he was given the chance to retract his opposition but refused. Before his execution, Sa'id asked to perform two units of prayer. He was turned to face the east (away from the qiblah), but he recited:
"So wherever you turn, there is the face of Allah."* (Qur'an 2:115)

As he was executed, he repeatedly said:
"There is no god but Allah, and Muhammad is His Messenger."

It is reported that Al-Hajjaj suffered greatly after Sa'id's execution. Imam Ahmad ibn Hanbal said:
"When Al-Hajjaj killed Sa'id ibn Jubayr, the entire world was in need of his knowledge."

THE SCHOLARS OF MEDINA:

Several prominent scholars emerged from Medina, including:
- Abdullah ibn Ka'b Al-Quradhi
- Abu Al-`Aliyah Al-Riyahi
- Zayd ibn Aslam

These scholars played a significant role in preserving the knowledge of the Companions and transmitting it to subsequent generations.

Those who had a significant role in transmitting the knowledge of the Companions, whether in jurisprudence, hadith, or tafsir, left a profound impact. Although there were other notable Tabi'un, the fame and influence of these individuals were greater and more prominent.

In Tahdhib al-Tahdhib by Al-Asqalani, the following is mentioned in the biography of Muhammad ibn Ka'b Al-Quradhi:
"He was Muhammad ibn Ka'b Al-Quradhi, also known as Abu Hazim Al-Duni, an ally of the Aws tribe. He resided first in Kufa and then in Medina. He narrated from many Companions, particularly Ali ibn Abi Talib and Abdullah ibn Mas'ud."

Ibn Sa'd said about him:
"He was trustworthy, knowledgeable, a prolific narrator of hadith, pious, and righteous."

Awn ibn Abdullah commented:
"I have never seen anyone more knowledgeable about interpreting the Qur'an than him."

Reason for His Title (Al-Quradhi):
Al-Bukhari mentions that his father was among those spared during the incident of Banu Qurayza because he was a boy at the time. During this incident, the Prophet (peace be upon him) ordered the execution of the men from Banu Qurayza after their betrayal and treachery, while sparing the children, women, and non-combatants.

Muhammad ibn Ka'b was one of the eminent scholars of Medina in knowledge and jurisprudence. He used to teach in the mosque, but the roof collapsed on him and his students, burying them under the debris. He passed away in 111 AH. May Allah have mercy on him and bless him.

Abu Al-'Aliyah Al-Riyahi

His full name was *Rafi' ibn Mihran*, and his title was Abu Al-'Aliyah. He was a freed slave of a woman from the Banu Riyah tribe. He was a trustworthy Tabi'i from Basra, widely known for his expertise in jurisprudence and tafsir.

Notable aspects of his life:
- He met Abu Bakr.
- He learned the Qur'an from Ubayy ibn Ka'b and others.
- He also heard directly from Umar ibn Al-Khattab, Abdullah ibn Mas'ud, Ali ibn Abi Talib, Aisha, and others.

He stated:
"I recited the Qur'an ten years after your Prophet's death."

From an early age, Abu Al-'Aliyah had a strong desire for knowledge and was dedicated to its pursuit. This dedication made him excel, surpassing his peers, particularly in tafsir. Ibn Abbas greatly respected him, once raising him to his couch while the Quraysh were seated below. Ibn Abbas remarked:
"This is how knowledge elevates the honorable, even placing a freed slave on couches."

He (Abu Al-'Aliyah Al-Riyahi) had a strong passion for knowledge and dedicated himself fully to its pursuit until he excelled in it and surpassed his peers, especially in tafsir. Ibn Abbas (may Allah be pleased with him) held him in high regard, often raising him to sit on his couch while the Quraysh sat below. Ibn Abbas would say:
"This is how knowledge elevates the noble, placing even a freed slave on couches."

Abu Al-'Aliyah passed away in 93 AH.

Zayd ibn Aslam

Zayd ibn Aslam, known as Abu Usama Al-Adawi Al-Umari, was a prominent jurist from Medina. He was a close associate of Umar ibn Abdul Aziz during his caliphate and was summoned by Al-Walid ibn Yazid to Damascus along with other scholars from Medina to address an important matter.

He was a trustworthy narrator, well-versed in hadith and tafsir. He had a teaching circle in the Prophet's Mosque in Medina, where he shared his knowledge. He also authored a book on tafsir, which was later transmitted by his son, Abdul Rahman.

Ibn Ujaylan remarked:
"I have never felt awe for anyone as I felt for Zayd ibn Aslam."

On one occasion, he narrated a hadith without attributing it. A man asked him:
"O Abu Usama, who narrated this?"
He replied:
"O nephew, we were not accustomed to acting like the foolish."

Zayd had a large teaching circle in the Prophet's Mosque in Medina. It is said that Ali ibn Al-Husayn (the great-grandson of the Prophet) would sit with Umar ibn Al-Khattab's freedmen, among whom was Zayd ibn Aslam, and remark:
"A man should sit with those who benefit him in his religion."

Zayd passed away in Medina in 136 AH.

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3. SCHOLARS OF IRAQ

Several prominent scholars of tafsir emerged from Iraq, including:

1. Al-Hasan Al-Basri
2. Masruq ibn Al-Ajda'
3. Qatadah ibn Di'amah
4. Ata ibn Abi Muslim Al-Khurasani
5. Amr ibn Dinar Al-Hamdhani

These scholars were instrumental in preserving and transmitting the interpretations of the Qur'an to subsequent generations.

Al-Hasan Al-Basri

Al-Hasan ibn Yasaar Al-Basri, known as *Abu Sa'eed, was a leading scholar of Basra and one of the great figures of his time. He was a jurist, eloquent speaker, ascetic, and courageous individual. Born in Medina, he was raised under the care of Ali ibn Abi Talib (may Allah honor his face). During the caliphate of Mu'awiyah, he served as a scribe for Rabi' ibn Ziyad, the governor of Khurasan, after which he settled in Basra. His reputation and authority grew immensely, commanding respect and reverence. He would address rulers with boldness, advising and admonishing them without fear of reproach.

His Knowledge and Character:
Al-Hasan met 120 Companions of the Prophet (peace be upon him), and he was one of the most eloquent, devout, and knowledgeable people of Basra.

Imam Al-Ghazali said:
"Al-Hasan Al-Basri's speech most resembled that of the Prophets, and his guidance was closest to that of the Companions. He possessed remarkable eloquence, and wisdom poured forth from his speech."

Ayoub Al-Sakhtiyani said:
"My eyes have never seen a man more knowledgeable than Al-Hasan Al-Basri. He absorbed wisdom and spoke it fluently. When he delivered sermons, he moved people to tears, as though he had just come from the Hereafter, narrating from what he had witnessed and experienced."*

Al-Hasan was renowned for his soft heart, eloquent tongue, and the ability to stir emotions with his sermons. His words were deeply moving and effective.

Fearlessness in Truth:

Al-Hasan narrated Prophetic traditions (*ahadith*), but when recounting narrations from Ali ibn Abi Talib, he avoided mentioning Ali's name due to fear of the tyrant Al-Hajjaj. Younis ibn Ubaid once asked him:
"O Abu Sa'eed, you often say, 'The Messenger of Allah said,' yet you did not meet him. What is the source of your narrations?"

Al-Hasan replied:
"O my nephew, you have asked me something no one before you has asked. Were it not for your closeness to me, I would not have told you. In the time you see before you—during Al-Hajjaj's rule—I cannot openly mention Ali's name. Every narration you hear me attribute to the Messenger of Allah is actually from Ali ibn Abi Talib, except that I cannot mention him by name."

Al-Hasan's Advice to Umar ibn Abdul Aziz:

When Umar ibn Abdul Aziz assumed the caliphate, he wrote to Al-Hasan, saying:
"I have been tested with this responsibility, so guide me toward people who can assist me in fulfilling it."

Al-Hasan replied:
"As for the people of this world, you do not want them; and as for the people of the Hereafter, they will not want you."

Al-Hasan Al-Basri remains one of the most respected scholars of the Tabi'un, whose wisdom, eloquence, and dedication to truth continue to inspire Muslims. Let me know if you'd like further insights into his life or teachingsHe passed away in Basra in the year 101 AH and was buried there. May Allah grant him vast mercy.

(Masruq ibn Al-Ajda')

Masruq ibn Al-Ajda' was a Kufan Tabi'i (successor of the companions of the Prophet), reliable and trustworthy, and one of the companions of Ibn Mas'ud, who transmitted to us the guidance of the Prophet (peace be upon him).

He was a devout worshipper and a jurist, known as Abu Aisha. He became famous for his knowledge of Quranic interpretation (tafsir) and the narration of hadith. His father was the most skilled horseman in Yemen, and his maternal uncle was Amr ibn Ma'di Karib. Masruq also served as a judge, yet he did not accept a salary for his judicial duties. He was content, ascetic, and satisfied with what Allah had decreed for him, despite having dependents to care for.

One day, his wife came to him and said, "O Abu Aisha, today there is no provision for your children." He smiled and said, "By Allah, Allah will surely provide for them." And indeed, Allah provided for them abundantly.

It was narrated that he once met Umar ibn Al-Khattab, who asked him, "What is your name?" He replied, "Masruq ibn Al-Ajda'." Umar said, "Al-Ajda' (the mutilated) is a devil; you are Masruq ibn Abdur-Rahman." After that, Masruq would say, "I am Masruq ibn Abdur-Rahman."

Ali ibn Al-Madini, the teacher of Al-Bukhari, said, "I do not place anyone above Masruq among the companions of Abdullah ibn Mas'ud." He prayed behind Abu Bakr, met Umar and Uthman, and participated in the Battle of Al-Qadisiyyah with his three brothers, who were martyred on that day. Masruq was wounded, and his hand was paralyzed as a result.

He had a gentle way of advising and admonishing. Once, he went out with some of his students and climbed a garbage heap in Kufa. He said, "Shall I show you what the world really is? This is the world. They consumed it and depleted it, wore it and wore it out, rode it and exhausted it. In it, they shed blood, violated sacred things, and severed family ties."

(Qatadah ibn Di'amah)

As for Qatadah, he is Abu Al-Khattab Al-Sadusi Al-Basri. He was born in Basra in the year 61 AH and passed away in 111 AH at the age of 55. He narrated from Anas ibn Malik, Sa'id ibn Al-Musayyib, and others among the Companions. He was known for his exceptional memory and sharp intellect. It is narrated that he said, *"I never asked a scholar to repeat what he said, and my ears never heard anything without retaining it."*

It is also reported that he once visited Sa'id ibn Al-Musayyib, questioning him for several days and asking a lot of questions. Sa'id said to him, *"Do you retain everything I tell you?"* Qatadah replied, *"Yes."* Sa'id was amazed and asked him to repeat all he had said. Qatadah recited everything Sa'id had taught him, prompting Sa'id to say, *"I never thought Allah created anyone like you."* On another occasion, he said, *"No one from Iraq has come to me better than Qatadah."* Once, a document of Jabir was read to him, and he memorized it instantly.

Qatadah was blind from birth, but he was a prodigy in memory, intelligence, and scholarly excellence. Imam Ahmad ibn Hanbal frequently praised him and spread his knowledge and jurisprudence. He was a leading scholar in Quranic exegesis (tafsir) and jurisprudence, but it was criticized that he took knowledge from everyone indiscriminately. Hence, poets said about him, *"Qatadah gathers knowledge like a night wood-gatherer" (who cannot distinguish between what is beneficial and harmful).*

He passed away in Basra at the age of 55 and was mourned upon his death. May Allah have mercy on him.

(Ata' Al-Khorasani)

Al-Hafiz Al-Asbahani mentioned that he was born in the year 50 AH and passed away in 135 AH. He is Ata' ibn Abi Muslim Al-Khorasani, known as Abu Uthman. He was trustworthy, truthful, devout, and ascetic, excelling in worship and humility. He would spend the night in prayer and devotion.

It is narrated that he would call people to prayer at night, saying, *"O so-and-so, get up, perform ablution, and pray, for standing in prayer at night and fasting during the day is easier than drinking scalding pus."*

He loved spreading knowledge. If he found no students to teach, he would go to the poor and teach them, fearing the warning for withholding knowledge. He was well-known for his knowledge of jurisprudence, hadith, and Quranic exegesis. He was highly ascetic and pious. May Allah have mercy on him.

(Murrah Al-Hamadani)

Murrah ibn Sharahil Al-Hamadani met a considerable number of Companions. He was known as Abu Isma'il and was famous as Murrah Al-Tayyib (the Good) or Murrah Al-Khayr (the Virtuous) due to his worship and righteousness.

He was a devout worshiper, praying 500 rak'ahs (units of prayer) every day and night. Al-'Ajli said he was a reliable Tabi'i (successor of the Companions). He passed away in 71 AH. May Allah have vast mercy upon him and grant him paradise.

The Legacy of the Early Quranic Exegetes

These were the prominent exegetes among the Tabi'in (successors of the Companions), who derived their knowledge and insights from the noble Companions of the Prophet (peace be upon him). The generation that followed them, and subsequent generations of scholars, preserved the religion, Quran, Sharia, and its sciences and knowledge intact through oral transmission and teaching, generation after generation. This fulfills the promise of Allah: *"Indeed, it is We who sent down the Reminder, and indeed, We will be its guardian" (Quran 15:9).

The noble Prophet also foretold this, saying: *"This knowledge will be carried by the trustworthy ones of every generation. They will expel from it the distortions of the extremists, the false claims of the falsifiers, and the interpretations of the ignorant."*

Observations on the Interpretations of the Tabi'in

It is noted that some Israeli narrations (narratives from Jewish traditions) entered the statements of the Tabi'in. The authentic and weak narrations sometimes became mixed, and some fabricated accounts were attributed to them. Therefore, it is necessary to carefully differentiate between authentic and weak narrations and refer to reliable sources of Quranic exegesis, such as *Tafsir Ibn Jarir* and other authoritative works.

Imam Al-Suyuti mentioned in his book Al-Itqan after listing the renowned interpreters among the Tabi'in:

"These were the early interpreters, and most of their statements were taken from the Companions. Later, comprehensive works of exegesis appeared, compiling the views of both the Companions and Tabi'in, such as the works of Sufyan ibn 'Uyaynah, Waki' ibn Al-Jarrah, Shu'bah ibn Al-Hajjaj, Yazid ibn Harun, and others. After them came Ibn Jarir."


THE SOURCES OF TAFSEER
1. QUR'AN
2. HADITH:
3. NARRATIONS OF COMPANIONS:
4. NARRATIONS OF THE SUCCESSORS:
5. THE ARABIC LANGUAGE:
6. DELIBERATION AND DEDUCTION:

1. THE QUR'AN

The first source of the knowledge of tafsir is the Quran itself. Accordingly, it happens very often that a certain point which is brief and requires explanation is invariably clarified by some other verse of the Quran. For instance, in the following verse of Surat al-Fatihah, "Guide us on the straight path, the path of those on whom You have blessed...", it is not clear here as to who are those whom Allah Almighty has blessed. But, in another verse, they have been identified very clearly where it is said:

So, these are the people whom Allah Almighty has blessed, being the prophets, their true followers, the martyrs (in the way of Allah) and the righteous. (4:69)

Therefore, when commentators explain a Quranic verse, they first check to see if a tafsir of the verse is already existent elsewhere in the Quran itself. If such an explanatory verse exists, they elect to adhere to it as their first choice.

2. HADITH:

The words and the deeds of the Holy Prophet (upon him blessings and peace) are called hadith, and as it has been stated earlier, Allah Almighty sent him with the Quran solely for the purpose of explaining, openly and explicitly, the correct meanings of the Quran to people. Consequently, he discharged this duty with grace and excellence both by word and deed. In fact, his whole blessed life is, after all, a practicaltafsirof Quran. It is for this reason that respected commentators, in order to understand the Quran, have laid the greatest emphasis on the hadith as the second source of tafsir and it is in the light of hadiths that they have determined the meanings of the Book of Allah.

However, because all sorts of narrations – sound, weak, and fabricated – are included in hadith, research-oriented commentators do not accept a narration as trustworthy until it withstands the principles used in the scrutiny of hadith narrations. Hence, simply finding a hadith report somewhere and then employing it as a source of Quranic commentary is not correct because of the very likely possibility that the report is weak or even contradictory to stronger reports. Without a doubt, hadith verification and criticism is a delicate matter and venturing therein is the exclusive prerogative of those who have spent years in mastering this field of knowledge.

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3. NARRATIONS OF COMPANIONS:

The noble Sahabah, or Companions (may Allah be pleased with them all), had received their education directly from the Holy Prophet (upon him blessings and peace). In addition, they were personally present on the scene when verses were revealed, and they had themselves witnessed the circumstances and backgrounds of the Quranic revelation. Therefore, naturally, the recorded statements of these blessed souls are far more authentic and trustworthy in explaining the Noble Quran. Hence, in the case of verses the explanation of which is not found in the Quran or Hadith, statements recorded from the noble Companions (may Allah be pleased with them) are given the highest priority. Consequently, if there is a consensus of Companions on the explanation of a certain verse, the commentators follow just that and explaining it in any way otherwise is not considered permissible.

If the statements of Companions (may Allah be pleased with them) differ in the interpretation (tafsir) of a certain verse, then the commentators who come later examine them in the light of various proofs and arguments and then determine which interpretation or explanation should be given preference. In handling such a situation, an important corpus of rules and regulations already codified under the sciences ofUsul al-Hadith and Usul al-Tafsir have been developed, a detailed discussion of which is not appropriate here.

4. NARRATIONS OF THE SUCCESSORS:

After the Companions (may Allah be pleased with them) come the Successors (Tabi'in). The latter learnt the tafsir of Quran directly from the former. Therefore, their statements too have great importance in the science of tafsir, although a difference of opinion among scholars exists on whether the statements of the Successors are considered decisive in tafsir. Their importance, n onetheless, cannot be denied. (al-Itqan, 2:179)

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5. THE ARABIC LANGUAGE:

Since the Quran was revealed in the Arabic language, in order to accurately explain the Quran it is necessary to have a complete mastery over it. There are several verses of the Quran for which there happen to be neither any attending circumstance of revelation nor any related juristic or scholastic question. Therefore, in their explanation, neither the sayings of the Holy Prophet nor the statements of the Sahabah or Tabi'in have been transmitted. Hence, the only means through which such verses can be explained is the Arabic language, and it is on the basis of language alone that they are elucidated. Additionally, should there be some difference in the tafsir of a certain verse, then also the science of linguistics is used to run a test of veracity between varying opinions.

6. DELIBERATION AND DEDUCTION:

The last source of tafsir consists of deliberation and deduction. The subtleties and mysteries of the Quran are an ocean with no shore. Therefore, the more a person who has been blessed with insight into the Islamic sciences by Allah Almighty deliberates into it, the more he discovers ever-new mysteries and subtleties. As a result, commentators do present the outcomes of their respective deliberations as well, but the mysteries and subtleties so described are found acceptable only when they do not contradict the five sources mentioned above. So, should a person, while explaining the Quran, come up with a subtle point or independent judgment which is contrary to the Quran and Sunnah, Consensus (Ijma'), language, or the statements of Companions and Successors, or stands in conflict with another principle of Shari'ah, then it will have no credence. Some mystics in the past sought to describe such mysteries and subtleties in tafsir but investigative scholars of the Ummah did not consider them trustworthy because the personal opinion of any person that contravenes the basic principles of the Quran, Sunnah and Shariah have obviously no weight. (al-Itqan, 2:184)

6. DELIBERATION AND DEDUCTION:

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SECTION FOUR: FAMOUS COMMENTARIES ON THE QURAAN

NAME OF COMMENTARY: Tafsir Ibn Jarir: The real name of this tafsir is Jami' al-Bayan

It was compiled by 'Allamah Abu Ja'far Muhammad ibn Jarir al-Tabari (died 310 AH).

Allamah Tabari was a highly rated commentator, muhaddith (hadith expert), and historian. It is said that he continued to write for forty years continuously and would write forty pages every day (al-Bidayah wa 'l-Nihayah 11:145).

In thirty volumes, his tafsir enjoys the status of having served as a primary source for later commentaries. In his explanation of the verses, he quotes different scholars and then goes on to prove the position which, according to him, is weightier in light of proofs.

SECTION FOUR: FAMOUS COMMENTARIES ON THE QURAAN

NAME OF COMMENTARY: TAFSIR IBN KATHIR:

AUTHOR

Hafiz 'Imad al-din Abu 'l-Fida' Isma'il ibn Kathir al-Dimashqi al-Shafi'i (died 774 AH), a distinguished research scholar of the eighth century, is the author of this commentary.

It has been published in four volumes. In this commentary, emphasis has been laid on explanatory hadiths.

A special feature is his criticism as a hadith expert on different narrations, and from this point of view his book holds a distinct place among all books of tafsir.

SECTION FOUR: FAMOUS COMMENTARIES ON THE QURAAN

NAME OF COMMENTARY:
TAFSIR AL-QURTUBI: ITS FULL NAME IS AL-JAMI' LI AHKAM AL-QUR'AN.

AUTHOR

It was written by the famous learned writer and research scholar of Andalusia (Spain), Abu 'Abdullah Muhammad ibn Ahmad Abi Bakr ibn Farah al-Qurtubi (died 671 AH).

He was a follower of the Maliki school of fiqh and was renowned for his worship and piety. The basic objective of this book was to deduce juristic injunctions and rulings from the Quran.

While doing so, however, he has also provided the explanation of verses, research into difficult words, discussion of diacritical marks and the elegance of style and composition (rhetoric), and related numerous hadiths in his tafsir (and quite ably so). This book is in twelve volumes and has been published numerous times.

SECTION FOUR: FAMOUS COMMENTARIES ON THE QURAAN

NAME OF COMMENTARY:
AL-TAFSIR AL-KABIR
ITS REAL NAME IS MAFATIH AL-GHAYB BUT IS POPULARLY KNOWN AS AL-TAFSIR AL-KABIR.

AUTHOR

This is the work of Imam Fakhr al-Din al-Razi (died 606 AH).

Imam Razi is considered an imam of Islamic theology. Therefore, great emphasis has been laid in his tafsir on rational and scholastic debates and on the refutation of false sects. The truth is that his tafsir is a unique key to the Quran. The refreshing manner in which the meanings of the Quran have been clarified and the mutual link of the Quranic verses established is all too praiseworthy.

Most likely, Imam Razi himself wrote his tafsiras far as Surat al-Fath. Onwards from there, he could not complete it. The remaining part of the tafsir, from Surat al-Fath to the end, was completed by Qadi Shihab al-Din ibn Khalil al-Khawli al-Dimashqi (died 639 AH) or Shaykh Najm al-Din Ahmad ibn Muhammad al-Qamuli (died 777 AH). (Kashf al-Zunun 2:477)

SECTION FOUR: FAMOUS COMMENTARIES ON THE QURAAN

NAME OF COMMENTARY: AL-BAHR AL-MUHIT:

AUTHOR

This was written by ‘Allamah Abu Hayyan al-Gharnati al-Andalusi (died 754 AH),

A master of syntax and rhetoric in addition to many other Islamic fields of learning. As a result of his mastery of language, his tafsir is replete with discussions on syntax and rhetoric.

He places special stress on investigating the words of every verse, the difference in structures, and rhetorical devices.

SECTION FOUR: FAMOUS COMMENTARIES ON THE QURAAN

NAME OF COMMENTARY:
AHKAM AL-QUR'AN
LI 'L-JASSAS:

AUTHOR
This was written by Imam Abu Bakr al-Jassas al-Razi (died 370 AH),

The deduction of juristic injunctions and rulings from the noble Quran is the subject of this book.

Instead of explaining verses in serial continuity, he has taken up the juristic details as called for by verses which consist of juristic injunctions. Several other books have also been written on this subject, but this book enjoys a prominent place among them.

SECTION FOUR: FAMOUS COMMENTARIES ON THE QURAAN

NAME OF COMMENTARY:
AL-DURR AL-MANTHUR
ITS FULL NAME IS AL-DURR AL-MANTHUR FI 'L-TAFSIR BI 'L-MA'THUR.

AUTHOR
This was authored by 'Allamah Jalal al-Din al-Suyuti (died 910 AH).

Here 'Allamah Suyuti has tried to collect all narrations about the tafsir of Quran that he was able to find. Several hadith scholars such as Hafiz Ibn Jarir, Imam Baghawi, Ibn Marduwayh, Ibn Hibban, and Ibn Majah had earlier attempted to do the same and collect as many narrations as possible themselves.

'Allamah Suyuti assembled the narrations they had all collected in his book. But, rather than include the complete chain of narrators for each tradition, he found it sufficient to simply name the particular author who has presented that narration under his authority. If necessary, one can go refer to the original source to verify the status of the chains.

SECTION FOUR: FAMOUS COMMENTARIES ON THE QURAAN

NAME OF COMMENTARY:
AL-TAFSIR AL-MAZHARI

AUTHOR
This was written by Qadi Thana'ullah Panipatti (died 1225 AH).

He named his book al-Tafsir al-Mazhari after the name of his spiritual master, Mirza Mazhar Jan-e- Janan al-Dihlawi.

TThis tafsir is very simple and clear and extremely useful for locating brief explanations of Quranic verses. Along with the elucidation of Quranic words, he also included related hadiths in ample detail, and in doing so, he made an effort to accept narrations after much more scrutiny than that of other commentaries.

SECTION FOUR: FAMOUS COMMENTARIES ON THE QURAAN

NAME OF COMMENTARY:
RUH AL-MA'ANI: THE FULL NAME OF THIS TAFSIR IS RUH AL-MA'ANI FI TAFSIR AL-QUR'AN AL-'AZIM WA 'L-SAB' AL-MATHANI

AUTHOR
it was written by 'Allamah Mahmud al-Alusi (died 1270 AH), the famous scholar of the last Period of Baghdad.

The commentary comprises of thirty volumes. He made his best possible effort to make the tafsir comprehensive. There are exhaustive discussions on language, syntax, recitations, rhetoric, jurisprudence, creed, scholastics, philosophy, astronomy, mysticism, and related hadith.

He made an attempt to leave no intellectual aspect pertaining to a verse unexplained. In the case of hadith narratives as well, the author was more cautious when compared to other commentators. From this angle it is a very comprehensive commentary and no future venture in connection with the tafsir of the Quran can afford to ignore its assistance.